



ACTIVISTS HAVE CARRIED ON A SUSTAINED CAMPAIGN AGAINST GM FOODS

crops are new to India. In 2002, after an equally divisive debate, the government permitted the commercial cultivation of genetically engineered cotton called Bt cotton. Despite the widespread criticism that greeted the first cultivation of Bt cotton, it has been an unqualified success. Transgenic cotton is grown in 90 per cent of the cotton growing areas in the country, increasing yields by as much as 50 per cent in certain regions. Globally, since its introduction 12 years ago, Bt cotton now occupies over 40 per cent of the total cotton sown area and has been adopted by countries such as the US, China, South Africa and Australia. Disputes, however, continue about its efficacy, safety and environmental damage.

The criticism, about the safety and utility of genetically modified food products, is focused on the assumption that altering the genetic make-up of a food item is bound to have consequences, which could prove to be deadly. No adverse effects on health have been reported for any transgenic product introduced anywhere in the

world so far. Besides, it is a myth that traditional food has no toxic effects. But there are worries like allergic reactions as well as fears posed by gene transfer and out-crossing that may lead to unforeseen consequences like resistance to antibiotics. This springs from the worry that GM foods would cause genetic modification in those who eat them. While that is the consumers worry, farmers concern is that when GM crops get mixed with traditional crops, these may get destroyed.

The reason why the clearance of a GM brinjal has raised a fresh squall is that apart from it being the first time India would be clearing a GM food crop for commercial cultivation, it is the first time in the world that a genetically engineered brinjal is being introduced. GM crops are those in which the genetic material (DNA) is altered for some perceived advantage either to the producer or consumer. In the case of the brinjal, the problem farmers faced is a particularly pesky and re-

The Brinjal Brouhaha

■ A genetically modified (GM) brinjal that promises high yield and is the first of its kind in the world is likely to be cleared for commercial crop cultivation in India.

■ NGOs vehemently oppose such transgenic foods, saying they are unsafe for human consumption and would adversely impact the environment.

■ The Union Government has called for a national debate and opened the research to scrutiny.

“There are strong arguments for and against GM food. Our decision will not be influenced by any company or NGO. JAIRAM RAMESH, *Environment Minister*”